

"You're on mute!"

"WHY NOT 21 IN 21?" is what a lot of you might have thought when you saw this month's cover story. It's just one more technology trend or innovation that we'd need to come up with, right? "Ah I get it, 20 in 21 to spell out 2021 on the cover!" is what the rest of you are thinking, right? Not exactly. The main reason is because your favourite technology magazine will celebrate its 20th Anniversary in June 2021, and thus, we're turning 20 in 21.

What a year 2020 was, eh? Surprisingly good for a few people, but mostly bad for the world. We too have suffered immensely with the "new normal". This magazine especially has suffered loads of delays and in many cases been unable to reach so many of you. Many of you readers who used to buy Digit every month from the local newsstands or newspaper delivery agents, might not even be reading this, because the entire newsstand business has been all but wiped out. Thankfully, many of you transitioned from reading the magazine in print to reading it online on geek.digit.in or buying the print magazine online from store.digit.in. We're also ever grateful to our subscribers who have stood by us and understood our pains as we have been delayed almost every month for some reason or the other. If it's not a printer break down because technical and maintenance staff are unable to travel, it's couriers struggling to cross through quarantine zones or book space on the very limited trains that were running for some time.

In under 12 months, we've seen all of our lives turned upside down, and are just beginning to pick ourselves up once again to assess the damage 2020 and the pandemic left in its wake. It will take us years to recover in many areas, but we're hoping life can go back to normal in 2021, or at least return to something that resembles what was considered normal in 2019.

If there's one thing we've learnt it's how important technology is to our lives, and how we have adapted thanks to it. We're so intertwined with technology that I think we should start admitting to ourselves that we're well on the way to becoming cyborgs. Yes, we're used to the idea of cyborgs being cybernetic organisms that have both organic and mechanical parts, kind of like what's shown in the Terminator series of movies. However,

our cybernetic parts are in our pockets or worn on our bodies, and the enhancements are run in the cloud on billions of servers. This is the new normal that we've been living in for nearly a decade now, and something Digit has been talking about for almost 2 decades now.

What this pandemic did to technology was not to slow it down, but in fact to kick it into a much higher gear. More people used IP calling and webcams to communicate than ever before. "Am I audible" and "You're on mute" are probably the most used phrases of 2020, as are "Take care" and "stay safe".

It wasn't all rosy either, as more and more cybersecurity threats emerged, because more people online from home means more vulnerabilities opening out for hackers – the real experts at working from home. We have also (perhaps rightly so) given up on a lot of freedoms, and are more accepting of surveillance, movement tracking, being checked for temperature, and generally living under curfew at times. Of course it's for our own good, but it doesn't feel good to be restricted, does it?

Then again, 5G is coming, and with it we're finally going to be able to get a decent mobile network in India (or so we hope) that offers not just faster speeds but also lower latency to enable some innovative services we haven't even dreamed of yet. I'm excited to see some unicorn startups being built over the next few years in India thanks to our knack of innovating, especially in hard times.

You can read our cover story to find out more about the 20 innovations or technologies that we think will drive India (and the world) in 2021.

The best thing about writing in print is I don't have to say: "Am I audible?", even though I do feel like saying, "You're on mute" to all of you. We know that it is you who will drive and power us in 2021, and we are very, very interested in having conversations with each and every one of you to understand how we can serve you better. As I promised in my last editorial, we will be contacting you much more often in 2021, and we'd really like you to start writing to us as well.

We look forward to celebrating a memorable 20th anniversary with all of you in June. We'd like to wish all of you a very happy 2021, and wish you and your friends and family perfect health and happiness. 🇮🇳



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